The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

Donald Trump claimed the war with **Iran** is “close to over” as **Pakistan’s** army chief arrived in Tehran to try to advance peace talks. Asim Munir is close to Iran’s leaders and to Mr Trump, who has called him “my favourite field-marshal”. Meanwhile America’s Treasury Department imposed sanctions on more than two dozen individuals, companies and vessels linked to Iran’s oil trade.

Mr Trump claimed that **Israeli** and **Lebanese** officials would speak on Thursday for the first time in “34 years”, though the Lebanese government denied knowledge of any upcoming contact. Hostilities continued on Thursday morning. **Hizbullah**, an Iran-backed militia, said it fired missiles at northern Israel. Israel argued that Hizbullah was “forcing” it to continue striking south Lebanon, and urged residents to evacuate.

Mr Trump threatened to fire **Jerome Powell** if he refused to step down as Federal Reserve chair after his term ends in May. Mr Powell intends to stay on until the president’s pick to replace him, Kevin Warsh, is confirmed by the Senate. Some Republican senators say they will refuse to back Mr Warsh unless a criminal investigation into the cost of renovating the Fed’s headquarters is dropped.

Asian and American **stockmarkets** surged as investors cheered the prospect of an end to the Iran war. Japan's Nikkei index and the S&P 500 hit record highs. American investors were also buoyed by a set of strong earnings reports, with banks including Morgan Stanley beating expectations. The S&P 500 has rebounded sharply from a low point in late March.

TSMC, the world's largest chipmaker, reported bumper profits in the first quarter, up 58% year-on-year. Deliveries to North American customers such as Apple and Nvidia accounted for three-quarters of net revenue, which the company now expects to reach record levels in the second quarter. Insatiable demand for AI stocks has helped boost the company's share price by a third this year.

A 14-year-old pupil shot dead eight classmates and a teacher at a middle school in Kahramanmaras, in south-eastern **Turkey**, before killing himself. Officials believe the attacker used weapons belonging to his father, a former police officer. The attack came a day after a separate school shooting in the nearby town of Sanliurfa, which left more than a dozen people injured.

The share price of **Allbirds** more than quintupled after it announced it would stop making comfy shoes and become an AI and cloud-computing firm. Having sold its footwear brand last month, Allbirds will use a $50m finance facility to buy advanced graphic processing units and rename itself NewBird AI. Despite investors' excitement, the firm was hazy on what qualified it to make the extraordinary leap.

Figure of the day: 65.8%, the share of women who voted in India's last parliamentary election. Read about why more women than men are turning out to vote there.

Photograph: AP

The war and China’s economic recovery

China’s economy made a strong start to 2026. Exports boomed in January and February. The nine-day Spring Festival holiday helped restaurants and retailers. Consumer confidence rose to its highest point since March 2023 in February (although it remains far below pre-pandemic levels). Figures released on Thursday showed that GDP grew by 5% in the first three months of this year compared with a year earlier, faster than expected.

But the war in the Middle East creates many uncertainties. It has vindicated China’s strategy of stockpiling oil and continuing to burn coal, even as it embraces solar power and electric vehicles. It could also lift demand for those technologies overseas: EV registrations in Japan grew by 180% year on year in March, according to the country’s car-dealers association. But not even China is immune to the effects of higher fuel and feedstock prices. The war may hurt the country less than its neighbours, but it is still going to hurt.

Photograph: EPA

Limbo in the Gulf

Donald Trump is talking up the chances of more negotiations with Iran. At the failed talks last weekend, America's priority was Iran's nuclear programme. America seems willing to accept a time-bound moratorium on uranium enrichment rather than an open-ended ban. Iran would probably concede to that, although it will haggle: America demands 20 years; Iran offered five. That would not address Iran's stockpile of enriched uranium, nor whether it could build advanced centrifuges.

Iran cares about money. It wants America to lift not only "secondary" sanctions, which bar third countries from buying Iranian oil, but also "primary" ones that keep American firms out of Iran. The two sides may have to settle for a rough framework that would lift their mutual blockades in the Strait of Hormuz, see Iran pause enrichment and in exchange gain access to oil revenues frozen in foreign banks. That would fall short of a lasting peace, or the change in Iran Mr Trump wants.

Photograph: Getty Images

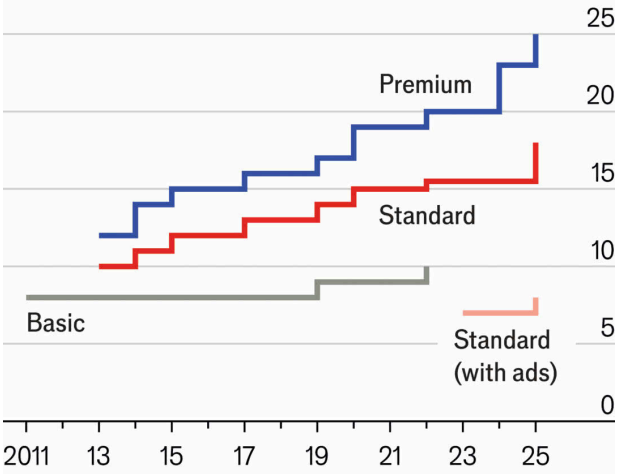
Tier today, gone tomorrow

A decade ago most Netflix subscribers were paying $10 a month. Today the streaming company, which reports first-quarter earnings on Thursday, is squeezing many of them for much more. A standard monthly subscription in America has crept up to $20; wealthier couch-potatoes can choose to pay $27 for better picture quality and multi-screen viewing. Budget-conscious viewers willing to suffer ads can opt for a $9 plan.

Netflix's market-leading position may have given it pricing power, but some European regulators are pushing back. Last year a German court upheld a ruling that the company could not increase fees without justification. This month a court in Italy found that Netflix had illegally raised prices over seven years, and ordered it to roll them back to 2015 levels and provide refunds (the firm is appealing the ruling). Spanish consumer-rights advocates have launched a similar complaint. Viewers may be persuaded to shell out, but now Netflix also needs to get judges to subscribe to its view.

Netflix and bill

Netflix, US subscription tiers, $ per month



Source: 9meters.com

Illustration: David Simonds

In for a chocolate penny

The fluctuating price of cocoa has left chocolate producers feeling bitter. It peaked at $12,000 per metric ton in 2024. Although it has since stabilised, food inflation has put off consumers. They are yet to rediscover their sweet tooth—a problem for Barry Callebaut, the world's biggest chocolate maker. The Swiss company, which processes roughly a fifth of the world's cocoa, reports earnings on Thursday.

At the end of last year, rumours circulated that Barry Callebaut might split the volatile and capital-intensive cocoa-processing unit from the more stable chocolate business, which supplies confectionery giants including Nestlé and Mondelez. But the company, which has had three CEOs in five years, seems interested in first righting the ship. In January it brought in Hein Schumacher, the former boss of Unilever, a British consumer giant, to oversee a turnaround. He implemented a cost-cutting drive, laying off staff and relocating production. Mr Schumacher will be hoping for a sweet rebound in sales.

Photograph: Getty Images

Football’s last innocent

Who are the greatest footballers of the 21st century? Two players seem beyond question: the magician Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo, an all-conquering machine. Both are now nearing the end of their long careers. But there is a third contender, too. Ronaldinho, who won the most prestigious titles with Brazil and Barcelona, had a brief prime compared with those other two giants. But he has endeared himself to football fans around the world like no other star currently playing.

A Netflix documentary series on the player begins on Thursday. “Ronaldinho: The One and Only” shows him as top-level football’s last true innocent, indifferent to the idea of becoming a global brand. Sublimely talented yet carefree, he delighted even opposing fans, who sometimes stood to applaud him. Ronaldinho represents something lost from a sport consumed by statistics and the quest for commercial success: the alliance of supreme imagination to guileless charm and pure, childlike joy.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which famous painting was stolen from the Louvre in 1911 and not returned until 1914?

Wednesday: Which American actress and film-maker directed the 2026 movie "The Bride!"?

Laughter is the tonic, the relief, the surcease from pain.

Charlie Chaplin